A Hindu can be *astika* (pious) or *nastika* (impious): the terms are said to relate more to orthopraxy (action) rather than orthodoxy (belief), but action proceeds from a set of convictions. As an *astika* he can accept the sacredness of the Vedas, the existence of *atman* (the soul) and belief in God, or he can reject one or more of these credos and still be Hindu, an adherent of the *nastika* variant of Hindu philosophy. As an *astika* Hindu he can subscribe to any of the six major schools of philosophy, the Shad Darshanas (which I describe later); as a *nastika* Hindu he can declare allegiance to one of five schools, including Buddhism and Jainism, which after arising as reform movements against the ritualistic Hinduism of their day, were practically re-absorbed into the parent faith (though their adherents may not see it that way). Or the *nastika* can attach himself to the materialist Charvaka School, whose followers denounced most religious practices and devoted themselves to wealth and profit. The palette of options available is as colourful as the most inventive artist's.

At the same time, as a Hindu, I appreciate the fact that Hinduism professes no false certitudes. Its capacity to express wonder at Creation and simultaneously scepticism about the omniscience of the Creator are unique to Hinduism. Both are captured beautifully in this verse from the 3,500-year-old *Rig Veda*, the Nasadiya Sukta or Creation Hymn:

*Then there was neither non-existence nor existence,*
*Then there was neither space, nor the sky beyond.*
*What covered it? Where was it?*
*What sheltered it? Was there water, in depths unfathomed?*

*Then there was neither death nor immortality*
*Nor was there then the division between night and day.*
*That One breathed, breathlessly and self-sustaining.*
*There was that One then, and there was no other.*

*In the beginning there was only darkness, veiled in darkness,*
*In profound darkness, a water without light.*
*All that existed then was void and formless.*
*That One arose at last, born of the power of heat.*

*In the beginning arose desire,*
*That primal seed, born of the mind.*
*The sages who searched their hearts with wisdom,*
*Discovered the link of the existent to the non-existent.*